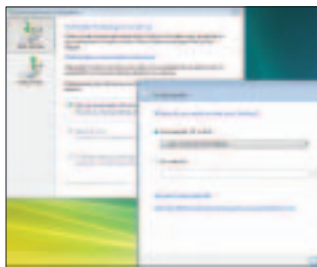


Other Vista features remain somewhat obscure because they take advantage of emerging technology. Sideshow, for example, runs a series of mini-programs that can be used to display different types of information on a separate screen, such as a digital photo frame, remote control handset or secondary display. Such mini-programs could allow you access to your email inbox, a list of RSS feeds you've subscribed to, a local weather forecast and more — even when your computer is switched off. It's a clever little trick, but not one that many hardware manufacturers have taken advantage of — yet.

Versatile Vista

The other thing we'll be doing throughout this Ultimate Guide is discovering hidden features within features you may already be familiar with. Take Windows DVD Maker, which comes with Vista Home Premium and Vista Ultimate. It's not much of a 'secret' in itself — Microsoft is more than happy to sing the praises of Vista's built-in DVD burning tool. However, what you might not know is that it can be used to create massive MP3 DVDs that can be played on your set-top DVD player or in your car. You can also burn DVDs of recorded TV programmes from within Windows Media Center. These are just a couple of examples of how many of Vista's tools are more versatile than you might at first think.

A number of other Vista tools sometimes get ignored because they can initially seem like they don't have a use that's relevant to home users. Meeting Space would probably fit this category fairly neatly. At first glance, it appears to be (and, indeed, was designed to be) a tool for businesses users. The little utility makes it possible to share what is displayed on your monitor with others on the



Windows Backup can be used to automatically copy files to CD or network folder to prevent data loss



Meeting Space can display a photo slideshow on the screens of several computers on the same network

same network. But, although Meeting Space was no doubt intended for making presentations to large groups of people during business meetings, it can also be put to other uses, including displaying photographs on the screens of more than one computer. By making use of Meeting Space, another computer on the same network, or a notebook connected wirelessly, can be used to display photos while you control the slideshow from another machine. The same program could be used to allow two or more people to research a topic on separate PCs and collaborate on a newsletter, or similar.

Putting them to use

Of course, not everyone will make use of all Vista's features. For example, while it's fairly easy to pop in a USB memory key to take advantage of the Readyboost performance enhancing feature, only those with special hybrid hard disks in their PCs will be able to make use of Readydrive.

Hardware requirements aside, there are probably dozens of features you may never want or need to use. Whether you ever investigate Vista's often overlooked built-in games, for instance, is largely a matter of taste. But for all the features you're likely to ignore, there are dozens more you'll find useful, and once you find out how handy they are, you'll wonder how you ever lived without them.

Our aim with this Ultimate Guide is to point you in the direction of these useful features and show you how to get more from your Windows PC. There's a lot to learn, but the resulting knowledge will vastly improve your computer skills and there's also a great deal of fun to be had along the way. Read on to venture into uncharted waters and maximise your PC's potential.